

Alpha ex Machina

The CRO Card Game

A competitive enterprise risk management game for 2–4 players

You are the Chief Risk Officer of a leading financial company. So is everyone else at this table. Your job is to build a company that can survive the worst the world can throw at it; everyone else's job is to find out whether it can. Every Stress Test card is a stress test: a Category 5 landfall, a sudden rate shock, a pandemic. Some come off a shared pile and hit the whole table at once; others are surprise inspections you aim at one rival's book. The last company still solvent wins. The first to fail learns the oldest lesson in risk management: the Stress Test you didn't plan for is the one that hits you.

What you need

- One starter deck per player: a CEO card, a Headquarters card, 40 deck cards, and 10 Stress Tests (print from `print_sheets/`).
- Something to track Surplus (a notepad, dice, or poker chips).
- A first-player marker. Nothing goes on the cards: where a card sits shows whether it is available or committed (see *Committing cards*).

How you win

You win by being the last company solvent or by reaching at least 60 Surplus, twice your starting amount. The start and target are the same at tables of 2, 3, or 4 players. There is no round limit. Finish the current action or Stress Test, including start-of-turn settlement and any follow-up effects, before checking Surplus. Companies that reach the target together share the win.

Leverage and Surplus

The game runs on two numbers, the same two every financial company watches.

- **Leverage** is other people's money that you put to work this turn: an insurer's premiums, a bank's deposits, a fund's investor capital and borrowing. Each funding source has the capacity to put 1 Leverage to work each turn: **commit** the funding source to use it. Your committed funding sources become available again at the start of your turn, and Leverage you don't use is simply gone. Leverage pays for investments, programs, Surprise Inspections, Talent hires, tools, and branch offices.
- **Surplus** is your capital: the cushion that absorbs losses. Stress Tests cost you Surplus. If your Surplus is 0 or less after a Stress Test resolves, your company is insolvent.

Leverage is what you can deploy; Surplus is what you can lose.

The cards

Funding sources

You may add one **funding source** per turn. It is where your money comes from. Each belongs to a category: an insurer's funding sources are the policies it sells (Life, Annuity, Health, P&C, and Specialty), and banks and funds use **Financials** funding sources (see *Financials*). Each funding source has 1 Leverage of capacity, but it also carries **exposures** (risks Stress Tests can hit) and sometimes **hedgies** (risks it offsets). At the start of your turn, before refreshing, each uncommitted funding source pays its **Margin** in Surplus, plus applicable employee and tool bonuses. Insurance products have base Margin equal to their printed exposure count minus 2, with a minimum of 1. Financials funding sources, including Funding Agreement Notes, have zero base Margin. Adding a source pays no Margin immediately. Carrying costs remain payable whether the source is committed or uncommitted.

Investments

Pay the Leverage cost. At the start of each of your turns, an investment pays its **Yield** in Surplus. A few pay in cards instead: they have no Yield and raise your maximum hand size by 1. Most investments have a **Sale** value: at any time you may liquidate one for that much Leverage or that much Surplus. **Illiquid** investments can't be sold. Investments carry exposures too, and some are destroyed outright by specific Stress Tests.

Programs

Your risk management. Three kinds:

- **Treaties** cost Leverage to put in play, then stay in play. Some have a **carrying cost**: at the start of your turn, pay it in Surplus or discard the treaty. That is the reinsurance premium, and it comes out of capital. You can't pay a carrying cost with your last Surplus. Broad treaties (Quota Share, Side Letter, Catastrophe XoL, and Dynamic Hedging) cost 1 Surplus a turn; a treaty that halves one kind of loss has no carrying cost. A treaty that makes one kind of exposure not count (the swaps and the credit line) costs 1 Surplus a turn for every exposure of that kind you carry, even hedged ones, including exposures converted into that kind.
- **Covers** attach to one of your funding sources or investments and stop its exposures from counting.
- Some treaties and covers can fail. Like an investment, such a program says which Stress Tests destroy it ("Destroyed if a Market Stress Test hits you"). When one of those Stress Tests hits you, the program is destroyed before it prevents or regains anything: protection is only as good as whoever sold it.
- **Responses** are played while a Stress Test is being run. Leverage you leave available is what pays for them. One Response, Fire Sale, answers a sale instead (see *Fire sales*). Another, Everything Is Securities Fraud, aims at an opponent: when the Stress Test ends, that company loses as much Surplus again as Stress Tests have cost it this round. The suit isn't a Stress Test, so nothing prevents it, and a second suit doesn't count the first.

Talent

Exceptional employees. Hire them by paying their Hire cost in *Leverage*. Many require a funding source of a particular category. You control at most one copy of each employee.

Tools

Things your company buys: a Market Data Terminal, a Corporate Jet, a Mobile App. Buy one on your turn by paying its **Price** in *Leverage*. Buying a tool isn't a talent move, and you control at most one copy of each tool. A tool stays in play and works like an employee who can't be

poached or fired; some have an ability that says **Commit**. A tool may require a funding source of a particular category or have a carrying cost. Some tools carry exposures, like a line or an investment: a connected device is something to hack. And like an investment, a tool may say which Stress Tests destroy it.

CEO

Your company's leader, a named Signature Talent card that starts in hand outside your 40-card deck. Pay its printed Hire number in Leverage to play it. Its abilities work only in play. It cannot be poached. If fired, it returns to your hand.

Headquarters and offices

Choose one Office Location as your **Headquarters**: it starts free on your board, outside your 40-card deck, and stays until your company leaves the game. Other Office Locations go in the deck and cost their printed **Open** price in Leverage. Opening a branch uses the same staffing move as hiring. Each company may control one of each city; different companies may use the same city. Offices are not employees: they cannot be poached or fired. They make no Leverage and pay no ordinary Margin.

Stress Tests

Market shocks, disasters, and crises. Each deck lists 10 of them outside its 40 cards. At the start of the game you pick 5 for a shared pile, and after every round the top card of the pile hits every company. They cost nothing and have no runner (see *The Stress Test pile*).

Surprise Inspections

Stress Tests in your main deck that you aim at rivals: examinations, lawsuits, short reports, and bank runs. Pay the cost in Leverage to run one at a target opponent, or at each opponent, on your turn or at the end of another company's turn (see *Running a Surprise Inspection*).

Deck limits and investment choices

Signature and Staple. Your deck may contain up to 3 copies of a card. A card marked **Signature** is one of a kind, such as a named event, a named person, or a single deal: only one copy per deck. A card marked **Staple**, such as Whole Life or Retail Deposits, allows any number. You may include different Signature cards, and opponents may have their own copies. Unnamed Talent cards allow up to 3 copies per deck. These are deck-building limits. They add no restriction on cards in play. Your CEO still starts outside the 40 cards and cannot also be in your deck. The same limits apply to your 10 Stress Tests.

AI cards. Investments and tools marked **AI** ride the AI boom. When *AI Bubble Bursts* hits a company, that company discards every AI card it controls after paying its losses.

Bay Area makes every AI investment you play cost 1 less Leverage, to a minimum of 1. This works as Headquarters or a branch; opening a branch costs 3. Its discount combines with New York's first-investment discount, still to a minimum of 1. AI tools and NFTs do not qualify.

- **Meme Stock** cannot be sold until the start of your next turn, including forced sales and automatic sales to stay solvent. Turns taken by opponents do not unlock it.
- **Vulture Fund** pays on the first distressed sale by an opponent each round, including voluntary, automatic, and forced sales. Count the seller's Surplus before the sale. Pay the Fund immediately after the sale, before a Fire Sale response or elimination. Automatic sales resolve in seat order. Forced sales do not open further Fire Sale windows.

- **Strategic Stake** names a living rival when played. Keep that rival's name beside the card. Destroy it, and discard its attached cover, if that rival becomes insolvent, including during a chain of failures. Conceding is not insolvency and does not destroy the Stake.
- **Patent Portfolio** offers its cash-or-card choice before you pay carrying costs. Each copy offers its own choice. If both your deck and discard pile are empty, take the Surplus.

Committing cards

Funding sources, employees, and tools are either **available** or **committed**. Commit a funding source to put its 1 Leverage to work. Commit an employee or a tool to use an ability that says **Commit**. A committed card stays committed until the start of your next turn, when all your cards become available again.

On paper, show a committed card by sliding it forward, toward the middle of the table, like chips pushed into a pot. At the start of your turn, collect Margin from your uncommitted funding sources, then slide your committed cards back. Automatic Leverage payments use floating Leverage first, then commit sources from lowest to highest Margin. Equal Margins follow board order.

Financials

Four starter decks are banks and funds rather than insurers. Their funding sources are **Financials** funding sources: the money they raise. They work like any other funding source: you add one a turn, it has 1 Leverage of capacity, and its base Margin is zero. This includes Retail Deposits, Venture Deposits, Banking as a Service, Funding Agreement Notes, and Evergreen Credit. Financials talent and programs need a Financials funding source to hire or play.

- **Retail Deposits** carry a **Short-Term Rates** exposure (Margin 0): rising rates make deposits dearer. But a third of your Retail Deposits, rounded down, have no exposure, so seven deposits carry five. Those are **core deposits**, the checking and savings money that stays put when rates rise. Core and exposed deposits both have zero Margin. A cover on a deposit still takes an exposure off. A **bank run** (Bank Run is one) makes each company it hits discard half its Retail Deposits, rounded down. Venture Deposits and Evergreen Credit can run too: a bank run counts them with your Retail Deposits and takes half of all of them together. Deposit Insurance stops that.
- **Investor Capital** carries a **Short-Term Equity** exposure (Margin 0): investors pull money when markets fall.
- **Private Credit** carries no exposure and pays no Margin, but its **carrying cost** is $1\frac{1}{2}$ Surplus a turn.
- **Margin Credit** carries no exposure and pays no Margin. Its carrying cost is 1 Surplus a turn, and your capital limits it: at the end of your turn, keep only 1 Margin Credit for every 10 Surplus you have, and discard the rest. That is a **margin call**. It waits for the end of your own turn, so a loss on someone else's turn doesn't call your credit until then.
- **Loans and dealing businesses are investments**, not funding sources: they don't raise money, they are what the money buys. Credit Cards, Mortgage Lending, and Prime Brokerage carry a **Credit** exposure: borrowers who stop paying. Subprime Meltdown, a Supervisory Stress Test, and a credit crunch hit Credit. M&A Advisory and the Trading Desk carry equity risk.

carrying costs round down. Add up all the carrying costs you are paying, then round down: one Private Credit costs 1, two cost 3, three cost 4.

Setup

Every named Talent has one pre-made deck, and each pre-made deck uses its assigned CEO. Decks follow their CEO's theme; they are not designed for equal strength. To choose a different named CEO, build a custom deck.

1. Each player puts their Headquarters face up on the table, puts their chosen CEO in hand, shuffles their separate 40-card deck, and keeps their 10 Stress Tests aside.
2. Everyone starts with **30 Surplus**, at every table size.
3. Draw 5 cards in addition to your CEO. You may **redraw** once: keep your CEO in hand, shuffle the other 5 cards back, and draw 5 new cards.
4. **Scouting report.** Every player shows the 5 cards they kept to the table, beside their CEO and Headquarters, then takes them back into hand.
5. **Pick Stress Tests.** Each player secretly chooses 5 of their 10 Stress Tests and puts them face down in the middle of the table. Set the other 5 aside for the rest of the game. Shuffle all the picks together into one face-down **Stress Test pile**.
6. Choose a first player and give them the first-player marker.

A round

Starting with the first player, each company takes one turn. Turn order stays fixed each round, skipping companies that have left the game. After the last turn, the round ends with a **stress testing round**: the top card of the Stress Test pile hits every company.

Your turn

1. **Margin and refresh.** Collect Margin from each uncommitted funding source. Then your committed funding sources, talent, offices, and tools become available.
2. **Settle.** In this order:
 - a. Pay any interest you owe from a Surplus Note or credit line.
 - b. Collect your offices' income and your investments' Yield.
 - c. From round 4, pay the round's **dividend** in Surplus (see *Dividends*).
 - d. Pay the carrying costs on your treaties, funding sources, investments, and tools in Surplus, or discard the ones you stop paying for. Add it all up, then round down.
3. **Refill.** Draw until you hold your **maximum hand size**: 5, plus or minus what cards in play say. Your CEO counts. If you already hold that many or more, draw nothing. If your deck is empty, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck and keep drawing.
4. **Operate.** In any order, as often as you can pay for it:
 - Add **one** funding source. Its capacity is available immediately; Margin waits until a later turn.

- Make **one staffing move**: hire an employee or **open** an office from your hand. Extra talent moves also allow offices.
 - Buy tools.
 - Play investments, treaties, and covers.
 - Run Surprise Inspections at your rivals.
 - Use abilities, liquidate investments, or close a branch without a refund.
 - Discard any cards you don't want; your next refill replaces them.
5. **Close.** If you control more Margin Credit than 1 per 10 Surplus, discard the extras (a margin call). There is no hand limit. Then each other company, in turn order, may run **one** Surprise Inspection from its hand, paying its Leverage. Each one runs in full before the next company chooses.

The Stress Test pile

After every company has taken its turn, turn over the top card of the Stress Test pile. It hits **every company**. It costs no Leverage, and it has no runner: nobody knows whose pick it was, and nobody can pay to push it through a Stop. Run it as described in *Running a Stress Test*, then put it face up beside the pile, on the used Stress Tests. Then the next round begins.

- **Developing events** hit with stage 1 when they come off the pile. At the end of each later round, the next stage hits instead of a new card. Keep the event on top of the pile and turn it a quarter turn after each stage. After the last stage, it goes on the used Stress Tests.
- **Looking ahead.** The pile stays face down. A **Scenario Planner** (an employee) or an **Early Warning System** (a tool) can commit on its owner's turn to look at the top card. Only its owner sees it; put the card back without changing the order.
- When the pile runs out, shuffle the used Stress Tests into a new pile.
- A company picks Stress Tests that hurt its rivals more than itself. Every pick also hits the company that picked it.

Dividends

Shareholders expect to be paid, and the longer the game runs, the more they expect. From round 4, at the start of your turn, after you collect income and before you pay carrying costs, pay a **dividend** in Surplus: 1 in rounds 4 and 5, 2 in rounds 6 and 7, and 1 more every 2 rounds after that. Nothing lowers it. The dividend leaves the game. A dividend you can't pay makes you insolvent after you sell investments, as usual (see *Insolvency*). On paper, the first player keeps the round count with a die.

Running a Surprise Inspection

On your turn, or at the end of another company's turn, choose a Surprise Inspection from your hand and pay its cost in Leverage. For a target-opponent card, choose the target. A card that says **Escalate** may hit every opponent instead: pay 2 more Leverage. Then run it as a Stress Test.

Running a Stress Test

1. **Response window.** For a Surprise Inspection, start with the player to the runner's left and end with the runner. For a card from the pile, start with the first player and go in turn order. Each player may do any of the following, then pass:

- play Response cards;
- commit talent, offices, or tools to use their abilities;
- liquidate investments or draw on a credit line to raise Leverage.

There are no responses to responses. When someone **stops** a Surprise Inspection, it is called off. The player who ran it may pay extra Leverage to keep it going only if the Stop names a price. Risk Committee Veto allows no such payment. A Stress Test from the pile has no runner: a Stop protects only the company that plays it, and the card still hits everyone else. Only a company the Stress Test hits can stop it, and an **Act of God** can't be stopped at all.

2. **Resolve.** Every company the Stress Test hits works out its loss (below) and pays it from Surplus. Then apply the card's other effects, destroy any investments and tools the Stress Test wipes out, and pay natural-hedge gains.
3. **Check for insolvency.**

A Stress Test in the middle of another

Emergency Equity Infusion lets each opponent holding a Bank Run run it at once, in turn order, without paying Leverage. A Stress Test run this way is run in full right then, with its own response window, resolution, and insolvency check. A free Bank Run targets one opponent and cannot Escalate. Then the Stress Test it interrupted picks up where it left off, and the player who played the infusion may go on responding to it. If the company running the interrupted Stress Test has gone insolvent in the meantime, that Stress Test is called off.

Crypto and the table price

Crypto is a Staple investment with Yield 1, one Low Interest Rates exposure, one Short-Term Rates exposure, and no printed hedges. Its Cost is $N + 1$ Leverage and its Sale is N , where N counts Crypto on all living companies' boards, including NFT copies of Crypto. Count before buying or selling. Ordinary discounts apply to this live cost. Each successive sale lowers the next quote. A Fire Sale uses one shared quote before the whole batch leaves play; NFT copies themselves still sell for zero.

Captive

Captive is an investment that counts as one Life, Annuity, Health, P&C, and Specialty funding source for requirements and counts. Count each Captive once when several categories match, including office income. It also counts for losses and carrying costs charged per funding source. It never counts as Financials or as a specific named funding card.

Keep it with your investments. It costs 2 Leverage, provides no Yield, Leverage, or Margin, and buying it does not use your funding-source allowance. It remains an investment for covers and removal. Its funding ability ends when it leaves play, and an NFT copying it does not gain that ability.

NFT copies

Pay $2N$ Leverage, where N is the total number of NFT cards already on all living companies' boards, counting transformed NFTs in every board area. The first NFT is free; subsequent costs are 2, 4, 6, and so on while those NFTs remain in play. Choose any other card on the board, including a CEO, an office, or a developing event. NFT takes its name, art, and type, but none of its value, exposures, hedges, or abilities. A copied funding source cannot produce Leverage, and a copied developing event has no stages. It keeps its copied identity if the original leaves the board; when the NFT itself leaves, it is an NFT again. Other cards count its copied identity for bonuses and conditions, including Crypto prices, Chicago futures, farm partners, office requirements, and core-deposit groups. It also remains an NFT when counting the cost of another NFT. NFT is a Staple: decks can contain any number within the usual 40-card limit.

Gov. Stress Test

Gov. Stress Test comes from the pile. When it resolves, take the most recent Surprise Inspection in each living company's discard pile, skipping cards of other types. Run a copy of each, for free, in turn order starting with the first player. Every copy hits every living company, even if the printed card normally targets one opponent. These copies can't be Escalated. Each gets its own response window and insolvency check.

The original cards stay in their discard piles, so ownership and Dark evidence don't change. Choose all the sources before running the first copy, and don't dig for an older card when a source has already been used.

Drawing and discarding

Your hand refills at the start of each of your turns (see **Refill** above). Some funding sources, investments, employees, and tools raise your maximum hand size while you control them. A Corporate Spy lowers each opponent's by 1, and Corporate Espionage makes its target refill to 2 fewer cards on its next turn only. Your maximum hand size is never below 2. A few cards still draw: employees you pay to draw, the Chief Economist's draw-then-discard, Patent Portfolio's choice, searches, and Accounting Standards Update. Running a Stress Test draws nothing. Some Stress Tests make the companies they hit discard. Whenever a card makes you discard, you choose which cards go from your hand, and they go face up on your discard pile. When you need to draw from an empty deck, shuffle your discard pile face down to form a new deck and finish drawing. If both piles are empty, stop drawing. Cards in your hand, on your board, or in an unresolved Stress Test stay where they are. Stress Tests from the pile never go into a hand or a discard pile.

Dark cards and the paper trail

Offshore Affiliated Reinsurance is a Dark treaty. Each Regulation exposure clause costs you 4 less Surplus, with a minimum of zero, after multiplying by your unhedged exposures. Flat fines and separate Dark-card charges still apply.

Some cards are **Dark**: they cut corners, so they are cheap and strong. A Dark card in your discard pile is **evidence**, however it got there: played, fired, destroyed, or discarded. Reckoning Stress Tests such as Whistleblower charge you for every piece of evidence in *your own* discard pile. Other Stress Tests charge for each Dark card on your board, including your CEO and any Dark employee you poached. Some Stress Tests have both clauses: count the board and your own discard pile separately, at the amounts printed. Cards in your hand or deck count for neither. Count each zone when losses are worked out, after Responses and before any after-loss destruction or discards. Reshuffling clears

evidence from the discard pile until Dark cards are discarded again. The Paper Shredder, a Dark tool, puts the top Dark card of your discard pile on the bottom of your deck when you commit it during a Stress Test that hits you. A Whistleblower destroys it, and then the shredder is evidence too. Cards always go to their owner's discard pile, so a poached Dark employee still leaves its trail with the company that first hired it.

Who a Stress Test hits

- **From the pile:** every company.
- **Each opponent:** a Surprise Inspection that hits every company except the runner's.
- **Target opponent:** a Surprise Inspection that hits the one company you choose. If the card says **Escalate**, you may pay 2 more Leverage to hit every opponent instead, for the same damage.

Escalate changes who is hit, not how much each company loses. Every opponent takes the printed clauses and riders once, with its own protection. Target-opponent card discounts apply in both modes. Only a normal targeted run adds its target's tax (General Counsel, for example). In a two-player game, both modes hit the same rival for the same damage.

Archegos Margin Call comes from the pile. Before Responses, compare the loss each company would take after board protection, before recoveries and gains. It hits the company with the largest loss. Every company tied for that loss takes the full hit, including ties at zero. Targets stay fixed during Responses.

Tail Dependence is a Signature treaty costing 4 Leverage. While any living company controls it, every Surprise Inspection becomes **Systematic** and loses the ability to Escalate: it hits every living company, including the runner, at normal loss. It has no target, so targeting taxes and discounts for target-opponent cards do not apply. A Surprise Inspection already running keeps its reach if the treaty leaves play during its resolution; later runs return to their printed reach when no living company controls the treaty.

Working out a loss

For each clause on the Stress Test (for example "4 per Nat Cat: Flood exposure"):

1. Count your matching **exposures** across your funding sources, investments, offices, and tools, applying any free exposure flips as described below, and subtract your matching **hedgies**. Never go below zero. An exposure marked **x2** counts twice. **Nat Cat: Any** matches every Nat Cat peril, and a flood, quake, or wildfire clause hits it. A card whose exposures can't be hedged or changed (Onion Farms) always counts them in full; see *Commodities*.
2. Multiply by the clause amount. Add any flat amounts and "per investment" or "per Program" amounts.

Then apply protection in this order:

1. **Programs that fail.** A treaty or cover this Stress Test destroys is gone before any of the steps below, so it counts for nothing.
2. **Covers and ignored exposures** (for example an interest rate swap) have already removed exposures in step 1, before the free flips.
3. **Halving treaties and talent.** Halve the matching clauses, rounding down.
4. **Flat reductions**, such as "each Mortality clause costs you 1 less."
5. **Swap payments.** Add them if the Stress Test has the clause your swap pays on.

6. **Responses, committed talent, committed offices, and committed tools** prevent what they say.
7. **Excess-of-loss caps.** An excess-of-loss treaty caps what is left at its retention, every time.
8. **Recoveries.** A cat bond sponsorship or adverse development cover gives back part of the loss.

Free exposure flips

Delta Hedging, Loss Portfolio Transfer, LDI Overlay, Equity Futures, Rate Filing, and Commodity Futures are ongoing treaties. They cost 0 and have no carrying cost. Each converts one unhedged exposure while it remains in play.

Card	From	To
Delta Hedging	Short-Term Equity	Volatility
Loss Portfolio Transfer	Litigation	Credit
LDI Overlay	Low Interest Rates	Liquidity
Equity Futures	Short-Term Equity	Liquidity
Rate Filing	Inflation	Regulation
Commodity Futures	Volatility	Inflation

Apply covers, ignored exposures, and existing hedges to the original book first. **Each exposure can flip only once.** A converted unit cannot feed another flip. Programs choose available units in the order they entered play, so Delta Hedging and Equity Futures compete for the same equity exposures. Extra copies do nothing until an eligible exposure appears. Removing a program or holding recalculates the book; these treaties have no voluntary discard ability.

Destination hedges and protection still apply. A swap's or credit line's per-exposure carrying cost includes exposures converted into the kind it switches off. For example, a Committed Credit Line charges 1 more Surplus per turn for each Liquidity exposure created by LDI Overlay or Equity Futures.

Counterparty Default charges 4 per Credit exposure, a flat 4, and 2 per program, before each company it hits discards a program of its choice. Loss Portfolio Transfer therefore trades litigation losses for a counterparty that can fail.

Volatility

Volatility is an exposure, separate from equity prices. A Volatility clause costs Surplus for each net Volatility exposure. **Delta Hedging** is one of the free exposure flips above: it converts one unhedged Short-Term Equity exposure into Volatility.

VIX Calls and Long Straddle are long-vol investments. Each has a carrying cost of 1 and gains 10% of the Surplus the whole table loses when a Stress Test with a Volatility clause hits its holder. First calculate every affected company's loss after protection and ordinary recoveries. Add those losses, before long-vol payouts, removals, or insolvency. Add the percentages of your qualifying investments and round the combined payout down once. For example, if the table loses 27, one pays 2 and two pay 5. You can collect even if you personally lose nothing, but only if the Stress Test hits you. For a developing event, only the stages with a Volatility clause trigger it. A stopped Stress Test pays nothing.

Inverse VIX Note is short volatility: Yield 3 and two Volatility exposures. The Short Volatility Note is short volatility too, with one Volatility exposure, and any Market Stress Test destroys it.

Volmageddon comes from the pile, hits every company, and charges 6 per Volatility exposure. Then it wipes out their Inverse VIX Notes, and as a Market Stress Test their Short Volatility Notes, without sale proceeds. Protection can reduce the loss but does not stop the wipeout. A company that stops it prevents both for itself.

Commodities

Oil Rigs, Gold Mines, Corn Farms, Soy Farms, Timberland, and Onion Farms are commodity investments. Each carries Volatility (the price) and hedges Inflation. Any Nat Cat Stress Test that hits its owner destroys it (the weather). Gold Mines carries two Volatility exposures and two Inflation hedges. Onion Farms carries two Volatility exposures. Oil Rigs is Illiquid.

Commodity Futures is a free exposure flip (above) from Volatility to Inflation. A commodity's own Inflation hedge usually absorbs the converted exposure, which leaves no exposure at all. If that hedge already offsets another card's Inflation, the flip adds an Inflation exposure instead.

Corn Farms pays 1 more Yield while you have an office in Des Moines, as your Headquarters or as a branch, for each copy. This is separate from Des Moines' own office income. **Soy Farms** pays 1 more Yield while it is paired with a Corn Farms you control, one to one (crop rotation): two Soy Farms and one Corn Farms earn one bonus.

Onion Farms has exposures that can't be hedged or changed: no hedge, cover, swap, or flip touches them, so they always count in full. Halving, prevention, excess-of-loss caps, and recoveries still reduce the loss, because they act on the loss rather than the exposure. There has been no onion futures market since 1958.

Talent, poaching, and your CEO

- You get one staffing move per turn: hire, play your CEO, or open an office.
- To play your CEO, pay its printed Hire number in **Leverage**, meeting its funding source requirement. The named CEOs cost 5. Ordinary-hire discounts do not apply or get used up. In campaign matches, rival CEOs cost zero Leverage; the player's CEO still pays the printed Hire. A CEO with a search ability searches when played.
- **Poach**: only a card that says **Poach** can take a rival's employee. Sign-On Bonus is a Response, so you play it while a Stress Test is being run, on anyone's turn. The Headhunter and Theo Blackwood commit on your turn to poach. Poaching is not a staffing move.
- To poach, pay the employee's Hire cost plus 2 Surplus. You must meet its funding source requirement, and you can't already control a copy. The poached employee signs a new contract and gains **Non-competes**, so it can't be poached back. It also arrives **committed**: it sits out gardening leave until the start of your next turn unless an ability uncommits it.
- A poached employee's abilities leave with it at once, even in the middle of a Stress Test. Protection it already gave stays with its old company.
- Firing effects include your CEO. When a Stress Test allows a choice, its runner selects the employee or CEO; effects with a Hire limit use the printed number. A fired CEO returns to your hand, loses its active abilities, and costs the same to replay. It cannot be poached. Ordinary fired employees go to discard. Tools cannot be poached or fired.
- Your CEO counts toward your hand size and can be discarded normally. Only firing returns it to hand.

- A committed card stays committed until your next turn unless an ability uncommits it. An uncommitted employee can step in again.
- You can't pay Surplus that would drop you to 0 or below.

Optional Surplus payment and uncommitting

Cameron Ellis may commit while you play a card to pay its Leverage cost in Surplus instead, one for one. Use the adjusted cost, including discounts, and keep at least 1 Surplus. Responses keep their normal timing. Shell Company, Affiliate Loan, Off-Balance-Sheet Vehicle, and Side Letter offer the same payment choice without committing a card. Carrying costs, ability costs, and the extra payment to push through a Stop keep their usual rules.

Executive Assistant and Delegation Dashboard may commit to uncommit a different non-funding card you control, including your CEO. Funding sources cannot be uncommitted by these abilities. Use these abilities during Operate or a Response, Fire Sale, or Stop-payment window. Each support card gets one use between the starts of your turns; uncommitting it or replaying the same card does not restore that use. Uncommitting never repeats arrival effects. On paper, mark the spent ability until your next turn.

Headquarters and office locations

- **Chicago** gains 1 Surplus at the start of your turn for every 3 Equity Futures, Commodity Futures, and Interest-Rate Futures you control, counted together and rounded down. With 0–2 futures it gains nothing, with 3–5 it gains 1, and with 6 it gains 2. Count only your own futures treaties in play; NFT copies count toward the group. This replaces Chicago's prevention ability.
- Your Headquarters and a branch use the same printed abilities. Only branches pay the Open cost. Offices have no recurring carrying costs.
- You may close a branch during Operate: discard it with no refund and no staffing move. You can never close or replace your Headquarters during the game.
- **Fully Remote** must be your Headquarters. Its charter cannot contain other offices, and it cannot share the board with them.
- A committed office readies at the start of its owner's next turn. A newly opened office can respond immediately. A prevention ability stops its printed amount in total across matching clauses, not that amount per clause.
- First-purchase discounts count actions taken earlier on your turn, even before that office opened; extra hires do not refresh them. London, Hartford, and Grand Bahama gain 1 Surplus at turn start for every 3 matching funding sources controlled, and Des Moines for every 4, rounded down. London counts Specialty; Des Moines pools Life and Annuity; Hartford pools Health and Assumed Reinsurance; Grand Bahama counts only Assumed Reinsurance and carries one Regulation hedge. Committed sources count. Each source counts once per office, and each office rounds separately. Assumed Reinsurance means that funding-source card, not other Specialty sources or protection treaties. Discounted prices never fall below their printed minimum. Hiring discounts never apply to poaching.
- Des Moines' extra income requires both a Life or Annuity funding source and a **Private Credit Fund investment**. The Financials funding source called Private Credit does not qualify. Multiple funds still give only 1 extra Surplus per turn.

Removing cards

Some Surprise Inspections let their runner choose one card of the target's to remove after Responses finish: a funding source, an employee or CEO, an investment, a Program, a tool, or a branch office. Only the indicated type can be chosen, and a Headquarters is never removed. Six of them each take one card of a single type: License Suspension a funding source, Reinsurer Insolvency a Program, Asset Freeze an investment, Noncompete Injunction an employee or CEO, Ransomware a tool, and Lease Terminated a branch office. From the pile, The Great Resignation fires every employee and CEO at the table, and Assets Nationalized discards every investment, including illiquid ones, and any attached covers. These discards pay no Sale value and do not trigger Fire Sale. A Stop prevents the removal with the rest of the Stress Test: a stopped Surprise Inspection is called off, and a card from the pile skips the company that stopped it.

Insolvency

When a company's Surplus is 0 or less after anything resolves:

1. It automatically sells its liquid investments, highest Sale value first, until its Surplus is above 0.
2. If it still has 0 or less, it is **insolvent** and out of the game.

Companies that fail at the same moment leave together. Some cards, like Too Big to Fail, make a failure cost every other company Surplus; if that drops another company to 0 or less, it fails the same way.

If Too Big to Fail makes all remaining companies insolvent, its controller wins, even though their own company is insolvent. Check automatic investment sales first. If several copies cause the final wave of failures together, their controllers share the win. In a chain of failures, only the Too Big to Fail controllers whose fallout causes the final wave win.

Fire sales

Fire Sale is a Response played right after a company with less than 10 Surplus sells an investment: for Leverage, for Surplus, or automatically to stay solvent. Count the seller's Surplus from before the sale. Starting with the player to the seller's left and ending with the seller, each player may play one. Then every company with less than 15 Surplus, including the one that played it, sells every copy of that investment it controls for half its Sale value in Surplus, rounded down: a Sale 2 investment fetches 1, and a Sale 1 investment fetches nothing. These forced sales don't set off another Fire Sale. Then play picks up where the sale left off.

Keywords

Act of God

This Stress Test can't be stopped.

AI

AI Bubble Bursts destroys this card when it hits you.

Carrying Cost

At the start of your turn, pay this much Surplus or discard the card. Add up all your carrying costs, then round down: two cards with a carrying cost of $1\frac{1}{2}$ cost 3. You can't pay it with your last Surplus.

CEO

Choose a named Signature Talent card as CEO. Each pre-made deck has one fixed CEO and is built around that person. Your chosen CEO starts in hand in addition to your opening draw, outside the 40-card deck, and stays in hand during the opening redraw. Play it on your turn for its printed Hire number in Leverage, meeting its funding source requirement and using a talent move. Its abilities work only in play. It cannot be poached. If fired, return it to hand; pay again to replay it. It counts toward your hand size, and other discards apply normally. Employees that fire themselves cannot be chosen as CEO.

Commit

Put a funding source, employee, office, or tool to work. A funding source you commit adds 1 Leverage, its capacity. An employee, office, or tool you commit uses the ability that names Commit. A committed card stays committed until the start of your next turn unless an ability uncommits it.

Cover

Attach to one of your cards when you play it. If that card leaves play, discard the cover.

Dark

A Dark card bends the rules. Once it is in your discard pile (played, fired, or discarded), it is evidence: some Stress Tests cost you Surplus for each Dark card in your discard pile. Other Stress Tests charge for each Dark card on your board. Some charge for both zones, separately. Cards in your hand or deck do not count.

Developing Event

Stage 1 hits when the Stress Test comes off the pile. At the end of each later round, its next stage hits instead of a new card from the pile. After the last stage it goes on the used pile.

Escalate

When you run this Surprise Inspection, you may pay 2 more Leverage to hit every opponent instead of one. Each opponent takes the printed loss and effects; the damage does not increase.

Exclusive

Fully Remote is a Headquarters-only choice. It cannot share a deck or board with any other Office Location.

Headquarters

Choose one Office Location to start free on your board, outside your 40-card deck. It stays while your company is in the game. A company can control only one of each location.

Hire

Pay this much Leverage to hire an employee or play your CEO. You get one talent move (hire, play your CEO, or open an office) per turn.

Illiquid

This investment can't be liquidated.

Margin

At the start of your turn, before refreshing, each uncommitted funding source pays its Margin in Surplus. Insurance products have base Margin equal to their printed exposure count minus 2, with a minimum of 1. Financials funding sources, including Funding Agreement Notes, have zero base Margin. Add any applicable Margin bonuses.

Non-compete

This employee can't be poached.

Open

Pay the printed Leverage to open a branch during Operate. Opening shares your talent move with hiring. Offices are not employees and cannot be poached or fired. You may close a branch without a refund; never your Headquarters.

Poach

Only a card that says Poach lets you poach. Take an opponent's employee by paying its Hire cost plus 2 Surplus. You must meet its funding source requirement and can't already control a copy. The poached employee gains Non-compete and arrives committed: it sits out gardening leave until your next turn unless an ability uncommits it. Poaching isn't a talent move.

Price

Pay this much Leverage on your turn to buy the tool. Buying a tool isn't a talent move. You control at most one copy of each tool, and a tool can't be poached or fired.

Response

Play only while a Stress Test is being run, before it resolves, unless the card names another moment.

Sale

Any time, you may liquidate this investment for its Sale value, taken as Leverage or as Surplus.

Signature

Limit one copy of each Signature card per deck. A card that is neither Signature nor Staple allows 3 copies. You may include different Signature cards, and opponents may have their own copies. Your CEO stays outside the 40 cards and cannot also be in your deck.

Staple

A deck may hold any number of copies of a Staple card. A card that is neither Staple nor Signature allows 3 copies.

Stop

A card that stops a Surprise Inspection calls it off, unless the player who ran it pays the extra Leverage the card names. A Stress Test from the pile has no runner: a stop protects only the company that plays it, and it still hits everyone else. Only a company the Stress Test hits can stop it.

Stress Test

A deck has 10 Stress Tests beside its 40 main cards. At the start of a game, pick 5 of them in secret; everyone's picks are shuffled into one face-down pile. After every company has taken its turn, the top card of the pile hits every company. It costs no Leverage and has no runner. Some employees and tools can look at the top card before it hits.

Surplus payment

Only a card or ability that says so lets you pay Surplus instead of Leverage. Pay the full adjusted card cost, including discounts, Escalate, and targeting taxes, one for one. Keep at least 1 Surplus. Follow the normal timing and other requirements. This does not pay carrying costs, other abilities, or the extra Leverage to push through a Stop.

Surprise Inspection

A Stress Test you run from your hand at one opponent (or each opponent) by paying its cost in Leverage: on your turn, or at the end of another company's turn. It goes in your main deck.

Systematic

This Surprise Inspection hits every company, including the one that ran it.

Uncommit

Make a committed card available again. This does not replay it or repeat its arrival effects, and it does not reset separate use limits. Executive Assistant and Delegation Dashboard each uncommit one different non-funding card you control between the starts of your turns. They can ready each other, but this does not restore a spent uncommit ability.

Yield

At the start of your turn, gain this much Surplus from the investment.

Starter decks

Deck	Line	CEO / HQ	Style
Mortality Mutual	Life	Eleanor Marsh, Mutual Founder. HQ: Des Moines	Patient. Builds a wide book and leans on mortality protection.
Retirement Guarantees	Annuity	Walter Ng, Spread Maximizer. HQ: Zurich	Back-loaded. Hedges markets and longevity, strongest late.
Medical Trend	Health	Dr. Priya Anand, Network Builder. HQ: Hartford	Fast. Wide book early; needs trend and regulatory protection.
Catastrophe Underwriters	P&C	Rusty Calloway, Cat Veteran. HQ: Munich	Swingy. Rich margins and strong cat protection; one missed hedge hurts.
Surplus Lines Syndicate	Specialty	Vivian Stroud, Syndicate Chair. HQ: London	Aggressive. Cheap Surprise Inspections; litigation and liquidity exposure.
Moral Hazard Holdings	Annuity	Theo Blackwood, Deal-maker. HQ: Grand Bahama	Predatory. A CEO who poaches your people, Surprise Inspections that strip your staff, and Too Big to Fail as a hostage.
Main Street Savings	Financials	Martha Kemp, Pillar of Main Street. HQ: New York	Patient. Deposits fund a wide loan book; rate shocks and defaults are the danger, but its depositors never run.
Bulge Bracket Partners	Financials	Catherine Voss, Master of the Universe. HQ: New York	Leveraged. Fee income from advisory, prime brokerage, and trading; its CEO makes its failure everyone's problem.
Two and Twenty Macro	Financials	Isadora Quinn, Macro Oracle. HQ: Chicago	Volatile. Picks rate and market shocks for the pile and profits when they land; one crash brings the margin calls.
Bear Raid Capital	Financials	Victor Crane, Bear Raider. HQ: Fully Remote	Predatory. Cheap Surprise Inspections and forensic research, plus a paper trail it hopes nobody reads.

Deck	Line	CEO / HQ	Style
Cam Capital	Life	Cameron Ellis. HQ: Des Moines	Draw cards, stop Stress Tests, and put Cameron back to work. Surplus can pay for a card when funding is tied up.
HODL Holdings	Financials	Max Moon, Treasury Evangelist. HQ: New York	Crypto prices rise with the table. NFTs count toward the story, and Treasuries earn income while the dividend bills keep arriving.
Second Act Holdings	Specialty	Marcus Reyes, Turnaround CEO. HQ: Zurich	Turnaround. Retain capital, raise equity, transfer old claims, and buy distressed assets while rivals restructure.
Regulatory Affairs	Specialty	Grace Okafor, Former Regulator. HQ: Hartford	Regulatory scrutiny. Protect a regulated book with compliance staff and legal cover, then send examinations, hearings, and enforcement actions at rivals.

Every starter deck has 40 deck cards and 10 Stress Tests, plus its CEO and Headquarters. Cam Capital has 14 funding sources; the original starters keep their existing mixes. Most physical Headquarters decks carry one different branch office; Cam Capital stays in Des Moines, and Bear Raid Capital is Fully Remote. Every starter retains two Dark card names and at least one reckoning. Mortality Mutual carries a Private Credit Fund to complement Des Moines.

Cam Capital combines Life and Annuity funding with Corn Farms, Soy Farms, Private Credit Fund, and Private Equity. It holds a large hand and carries eight Responses that Stop Stress Tests, including three Risk Committee Vetoes: pay 4 Leverage to Stop a Stress Test that hits you, with no push-through payment. Acts of God remain unstoppable. Corn Farms gains Yield +1 in Des Moines. Each Soy Farms paired with one Corn Farms gains Yield +1; spare Soy Farms do not. Executive Assistant and Delegation Dashboard put Cameron back to work.

Moral Hazard Holdings is the villain: a private equity roll-up that poaches your people, bets against you, and holds Too Big to Fail over the table.

The Financials decks: Main Street Savings is a community bank whose depositors never run; Bulge Bracket Partners is an investment bank of deals, trading, and prime brokerage, too big to fail; Two and Twenty Macro is a leveraged macro hedge fund that profits when rate and market shocks land; Bear Raid Capital is an activist short seller that profits from scandals and fire sales.

Building your own company (charter format)

- Exactly 40 cards, and a separate list of exactly 10 Stress Tests. Surprise Inspections go in the 40 cards; Stress Tests for the pile go only in the list. At most 1 copy of each **Signature** card, any number of each **Staple** card, and at most 3 copies of any other card. Most decks want 14–17 funding sources.
- Choose a **named Signature Talent card** as your CEO. Employees that fire themselves cannot be CEOs. The CEO starts in hand and isn't one of your 40 cards (so it can't also be in your

deck).

- Choose one Office Location as your Headquarters, outside the 40 cards. Do not include copies of your HQ in the deck. Branches count toward the 40 and the normal three-copy limit; only one of each location can be in play. Fully Remote cannot include any branches.
- Every Stress Test you pick for the pile hits you too. List the ones your own book survives better than the companies you expect to face. Pack Surprise Inspections for your rivals' weak spots.

Playing like a CRO

- **Your opponents are your reverse stress test.** Look at a rival's board and ask which Stress Test breaks it. Then look at your own.
- **Keep a way to respond.** Available funding sources pay for Responses. If you commit them all, keep a Surplus payment ability or a way to uncommit a card available.
- **A known threat already costs money.** When your Scenario Planner sees a hurricane on top of the pile, you start paying: treaty carrying costs, Leverage held back, cover. That is a risk load, and knowing first is worth the hire.
- **Read the scouting report.** The opening hands show what each rival is building. Pick the Stress Tests that find their exposures and miss yours.
- **Concentration kills.** Ten Mortality exposures turn one pandemic into an insolvency. Diversify your funding sources, or buy the treaty.
- **Find the weakest book.** Aim a Surprise Inspection where the exposure is, or at the company one hit from failing. Escalate when several rivals carry the risk.
- **Liquidity is not solvency.** Selling investments or drawing a credit line buys time, not capital.
- **Crowded trades unwind together.** When a company in trouble dumps an investment you also hold, a Fire Sale can make you dump yours at half price. A thick cushion of Surplus keeps you out of the stampede.
- **Borrow short, lend long, and watch the rate.** Most deposits reprice the moment rates move; fixed-rate loans don't. Hedge the gap before a rate shock finds it.
- **Leverage is procyclical.** Margin credit shrinks exactly when your Surplus does, so the loss that hurts you also takes away your funding.
- **Natural hedges pay twice.** A funding source's hedges offset other exposures, and some investments gain when disasters hit.
- **Key people are a risk.** Your best hire is the first one a rival's headhunter calls.
- **Conduct risk compounds.** Every Dark card is cheap today and evidence tomorrow, and the bill tends to arrive all at once.
- **Cards are options; Surplus is capital.** A card drawn today may save you tomorrow, but paying Surplus for cards thins the cushion that keeps you solvent.

A note on the Stress Tests

Cards based on real disasters are written as *as-if replays*: what would the same event cost today's books? That is how catastrophe modelers use history. Those cards keep a sober tone; the humor is aimed at markets, regulators, and corporate life.